

The Nature of the Problem. Each school day, America's 20 million adolescents decide how to spend at least five (40%) of their waking hours when they are not in school.¹ Without adult supervision these nonschool hours offer opportunities for high-risk behavior, including violence, substance abuse, and sexual activity.¹ For low-income youth, economic and social disadvantages in their neighborhoods are exacerbated by lack of places that are safe, have engaging activities and access to caring adults.^{1, 2}

Thousands of for- and non-profit community organizations attempt to serve these millions of youth through mentoring and educational activities during nonschool hours. Each connects adult volunteers with youth as mentors, coaches, tutors, and friends. Academic and social activities develop life skills, such as solving problems, developing friendships and social support, getting a job, and building ambitions for advanced education and careers. Some organizations are well known, such as the Boys and Girls Clubs, some are government service agencies, but most are voluntary groups of concerned citizens working out of churches, schools, recreation centers, and other donated spaces. Their contributions to youth development and productive citizenship are valued by communities and supported by research.^{1,2,3,4} But their young clients cannot pay for their services and are much more than their volunteer and part-time staff can serve.

While the importance of these community organizations is often praised by celebrities, media and public leaders, support for daily functions and resources to grow, become self-sustaining, and last long enough to produce their intended good is rare or absent.^{5,6} Their voluntary formation, lack of formal organization, and minimal funding, and absent supportive infrastructure force them to be self-reliant for knowing what to do and how to do it.⁵ Occasional media attention for volunteer recruitment and training conferences exist through a few regional volunteer centers and national organizations, such as the Points of Light Foundation and the National Volunteer Corporation. However, no local, regional, or national system exists for ongoing, systematic staff development, peer exchange, and program development, research, and maintenance. Barriers to such educational opportunities include lack of staff time and money, inappropriate learning opportunities (i.e.,

academic courses and degree programs often are irrelevant to specific and ongoing training needs), absence of leadership to create a relevant learning system, and assumptions that these volunteer and part-time staff do not want or need professional development.^{7,8}

The Nature of an Anytime, Anywhere Learning Solution. Since 1993, Chicago's Tutor/Mentor Connection (T/MC) has been creating a network of local, state and national partners dedicated to the development and expansion of tutoring, mentoring and school-to-work programs in Chicago and around the country. Toward this end, T/MC uses research, training, marketing, and network development to create a supportive environment for organizations that offer mentoring. T/MC's role as a support and infrastructure developer is unique and offers a model of a support system for community organizations serving youth (e.g., the National Mentoring Partnership recognizes T/MC as regional and national resource). T/MC grew out of its founders' 20 plus years of experience as volunteers in and eventually directors of youth programs dealing daily with the discussed barriers and challenges.

A TM/C-initiated survey in 1994 found that 55% of 120 Chicago organizations had little or no contact with peers, 75% said they would like more contact, and 90% said they would come to a conference for additional training and networking if little or no money was required.⁹ These results led to collaborations with hundreds of for- and non-profit partners to provide biannual conferences. Staff, volunteers and supporters (e.g., businesses, civic leaders) engage in workshops conducted by local and regional leaders on topics as volunteer recruitment and program evaluation. The conferences are excellent opportunities for networking and exchange of ideas, as attendance has grown to over 260 at each of the 1998 conferences (a 600% increase since 1994). Participant evaluations praise the value of networking and hands-on workshops. Many wish they could attend more workshops and report that conferences are one of the best hands-on experiences.

T/MC also leverages financial and in-kind resources for local organizations, produces an annual directory of all Chicago organizations and programs, generates maps of service and program distribution by community need, and creates links to new information and research. These and other

components also exist on a comprehensive web site (www.tutormentorconnection.org). However, these resources are lean compared to the mentoring initiatives' hunger for learning and support. T/MC seeks to create an Internet Based Learning Network for mentoring initiative staff, volunteers and supporters that will be a dramatic, but logical, expansion of the interactive learning environment T/MC developed over the past five years. For years, this project has been a dream of T/MC and local supporters. Most likely, it is a dream of initiatives and leaders across the U.S. T/MC's experience, trust and working relationships with organizations and supporters (now over 500 mentoring groups locally and over 11,000 contacts nationwide) create a unique opportunity to make this dream a reality. FIPSE can contribute to the creation of the first educational infrastructure for community organizations that serve youth through mentoring.

The Mentoring Learning Network. The Internet-based Network will be a dynamic, relevant, and stable education and infrastructure development system that 1) provides useful learning opportunities for what matters most to those seeking to make a difference through mentoring, 2) connects existing and creates new channels for knowledge, peer exchange, networking and collective action in the mentoring movement and 3) provides an on-line evaluation system through which mentoring initiatives' individual and collective findings are used to understand and improve outcomes for youth and communities.

In the Network, as in the conferences, those participating as "learners" are also "teachers." Most participants are professionals from various fields bringing diverse expertise and creating a rich learning environment. One aim is to re-create this environment experienced more often, more systematically, and with greater accessibility (with respect to geography, time and money) for all staff and supporters (e.g., businesses, civic leaders) of mentoring initiatives.

Learning/Teaching Strategies. Network strategies will build competence and products directly related to effective mentoring initiatives, including program development, volunteer recruitment, evaluation, critical thinking, marketing, collaboration, resource development, and institutionalization.

Participation will be free or at a low cost. Relevant technology will allow participation by those with visual, verbal, auditory, and typing disabilities. The following are samples of the Network's strategies.

- ⟨ *Synchronous Facilitated Workshops* will engage groups to learn skills applicable to creating products and action. For example, a workshop on program development would result in several ideas and a plan to create a specific program. Or, mentoring initiatives in a city might initiate a series of workshops with a marketing specialist to develop their annual volunteer recruitment fair. This product-emphasis should make participation worthwhile, generate new participation, and stimulate learning. Users and staff will nominate ideas for new workshops. Besides competence development, the key purpose of workshops is to create interaction, networking and collaborative work among participants. Network staff will plan regular workshops and users can self-initiate them based on their needs. Each workshop will include at least one facilitator (depending on the purpose and number of participants) to ensure fair and useful communication. Facilitators will be Network staff and others experienced as discussion leaders. Overtime more participants will gain experience as facilitators and initiate and guide real-time Internet discussions.
- ⟨ *Synchronous Leader Interviews* with local, regional and national leaders in the mentoring movement and related fields will regularly be conducted and broadcast on the Internet. Users will be able to ask questions by phone and email. Interviews will discuss specific competencies, products, lessons, recommendations, and aspirations in the mentoring movement.
- ⟨ *Asynchronous Discussions and Interactions* will include a managed Listserv for email interaction and exchange of ideas and products. Transcripts and audiotapes/files of synchronous discussions and interviews will be available on the Network.
- ⟨ *Production Rooms* will be virtual "working" rooms where one or more participants can choose preformatted or design their own guided tours for developing products needed in mentoring initiatives. These products might include a press release, a volunteer training presentation, a grant proposal, or an evaluation tool for a specific project. Production Rooms will include search tools for Network and other Internet sites and access to consultants and technical assistance (paid

and some free). Users will have the option to post their products on the Network and solicit feedback from the Network community.

⟨ *Learning Centers* will hold information, sources and products synthesized, distilled, and organized by Network staff from synchronous and asynchronous activities. Potential learning centers include Lessons/Products (e.g., success stories, new programs, practices, and policies supportive of mentoring), Challenges/Problems (to prompt for technical assistance and outside support and to generate workshops and interviews), Evolution/Pushing New Heights (new ideas and aspirations for improvement) and New Initiative Development (information on newly developing mentoring initiatives and ways for Network participants to help them).

⟨ *Mentoring University* will provide links to universities, colleges, resources for continuing education credits, and notices for upcoming learning opportunities around the country. Each link will include specific contact people knowledgeable in research and development of mentoring programs and available resources to support travel.

These and other strategies will create a self-supporting and continuously evolving Network fueled by its utility and direct applicability to what matters most to those in the mentoring movement. The essential aim is to go beyond providing information and become a source and resource for applied work, problem solving, innovation, and collective action. The Network will include links and summaries of Internet (e.g., other Listserv, Internet distance learning providers) and non-Internet information and tools. Though the unique aspects of the Network will be 1) hands-on learning opportunities specific to participant context, 2) means for participants to find and fill niches and needs of the mentoring community, and 3) opportunities for collective reflection and creation of shared standards, objectives and vision for the mentoring movement. Participants will teach and learn while co-creating an expanding, useful Network. Research and experience show that person-to-person interaction resulting in a mutually valued goal or product can improve skills, enhance problem-solving, increase collaboration on grants and projects, and effect program outcomes.¹⁰ The

Network's learning strategies will be designed to create the type and level of interaction and collaborative work needed for a continuously improving mentoring movement.

Implementation Plan. The initial lead partners - T/MC, Pilotstone Technologies, and the Chicago Bar Foundation - will work with current (Appendix B) and new partners to implement the Network. Cost share will increase from current estimates as new partners make commitments. T/MC director Daniel Bassill will administer funds, provide space and resources, and co-direct the Network. Network director Stergios Russos will have overall responsibility for the Network and work closely with the technology team and evaluators. Network technology management will include Pilotstone's Matthew Mead (T/MC's web manager), Julie Parish, T/MC's director of GIS mapping, and a network specialist. The Chicago Bar Foundation (a T/MC partner since 1994) uses its powerful civic voice, alumni, and financial resources to help create conditions for making mentoring and mentoring outcomes matter to the community at large. Specifically, the Foundation provides operating grants, publicity, and recognition for mentoring programs contingent on progress and leadership development by Chicago mentoring initiatives. The Foundation, a non-paid partner, will use these strategies to stimulate use among Chicago organizations and help other local and national grantmakers and support organizations adopt these strategies.

Timeline. From day one community, business, academic, and mentor initiative leaders will be invited participants in developing the Network and be encouraged to take what they find useful to their communities. Year 1: engage existing Internet-competent partners (e.g., Mott Foundation's After-School Listserv) to develop Network environment and avoid reinventing/duplicating resources; organize a formal Network development team from these contacts; engage participants with Internet competence to pilot test prototypes. Late year 1 onwards: subcontract/partner with Internet distance learning, conferencing, and technology trainers; initiate marketing with T/MC collaborators (over 11,000 on the mailing list). Year 2 onwards: subcontract with groups that provide non-Internet training and assistance to mentoring programs to expand Internet teaching opportunities. Year 3 onwards: enlist local and national academic institutions to enhance Network instruction and create

certification/credit processes for specific competencies. Year 3 onwards: expand nationwide exchange more systematically; focus on strategic planning and discussions for shared vision and action in the mentoring movement.

Evaluation. T/MC's history of inside (e.g., annual surveys⁹) and outside evaluation (e.g., Chapin Hall Center for Children¹¹) focuses on understanding and improving T/MC and mentoring initiatives. The Network's outside evaluation will be supplemented with increased T/MC-initiated research activities to more rapidly discover and apply lessons learned from participants and outside evaluation. Evaluation will include process, intermediate and distal outcomes of participants (e.g., competence, application, satisfaction), Network implementation (e.g., history of development, amount and frequency of use, user history), and the Chicago and Internet-sample community (e.g., addressing novel problems related to mentoring; degree to which the Network serves as a national model for Internet education). Internet, mail and phone methods will be used to collect quantitative and qualitative measures of users at their first and ongoing participation to assess how the Network can best meet the needs that matter most in the mentoring movement. Appropriate empirical designs, including longitudinal cohort, will be used to understand differences between participant and non-participants (e.g., among the 500+ organizations in the T/MC directory) while controlling internal and external validity threats.

On-line self-evaluation by participating organizations and mapping will help track and improve participant and collective outcomes, stimulate overall participation and collaboration, and engage grantmaker support for mentoring programs. Users will access an on-line data entry system to report 1) volunteer and student recruitment and related data (e.g., length and type of activities) and 2) new or modified projects, practices, policies, collaborations, media, and generated resources (this is an adaptation of an existing evaluation tool¹²). Users can retrieve these data in text and graph form to prepare reports, grants, media releases, and track their history of accomplishment. T/MC's current mapping system of mentoring programs will be expanded so that mentoring initiatives and supporters can retrieve and add to local, regional and national maps. Mapping analyses are used to influence

program development specific to local needs and concerns (e.g., poverty, crime, school performance). Analyses will provide ongoing understanding of relationships between Network participation, volunteerism and initiatives' capacity to influence their communities. Access to these tools and data will be used to promote and broker relationships between mentoring initiatives and grantmakers (e.g., Chicago Bar Foundation), legislators or others interested in mentoring outcomes and outcome-contingent support. Overall, evaluation will identify and prompt celebration and replication of promising practices, identify problems and redirect efforts, and describe means for replicating and adapting the Network and its components to other contexts.

Ultimate Network success will be measured by how well anytime, anywhere learning creates the conditions for mentoring initiatives to contribute to lasting benefits for youth and their communities. The Mentoring Learning Network can create educational equity for this segment of our communities. FIPSE financial support and the guidance and encouragement of FIPSE staff can help create this community innovation. We look forward to being a partner in community education, service and research with FIPSE.

Appendix A - References

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